

KNIGHTS' HELMETS

The helmets worn by the Normans in the 11th and 12th centuries were little different from the *Spangenhelms* of the Dark Ages – high, conical metal caps with nose guards. From the 12th century, however, rounder helmets evolved, which eventually covered the whole face. These great helms proved cumbersome and, in the 14th century, were superseded by basinets, which allowed the wearer extra mobility and visibility at the cost of some protection. Helmets appeared in ever greater varieties in the 15th century, including barbutes and the lighter sallets, as well as armets, which had hinged cheekpieces that fastened under the chin.

Flared sides

Ovoid, medially ridged form

▲ GREAT BASINET

Date Late 14th century

Origin England

Material Steel

The origins of the great basinet helmet go back to the metal skullcap worn inside a mail coif and under a great helm. The holes for the *vervelles* – rivet-like metal staples – that secured this basinet to the mail aventail are visible.

Triangular plates, riveted together

Copper rivets with silver-bound heads

◀ SEGMENTED HELM

Date 11th century

Origin Poland

Material Iron, copper

Segmented helms are typical of early medieval designs. This helm was constructed from four triangular iron plates, originally covered in gilt copper sheet, and joined by copper rivets.

Flame pattern on skull

Movable visor with double sights

Mail aventail

▲ PAINTED SALLET

Date 1490

Origin Northern Europe

Material Steel

Sallets were light helmets that developed from the basinet. They usually had a long tail to protect the neck. This one has a painted design, while others were covered with cloth.

▲ SHORT-TAILED SALLET

Date c.1440

Origin Northern Italy

Material Steel

Originally from Italy, sallets were worn by both knights and foot soldiers. This one has a much shorter tail than many other types, and does not have a visor.